knowledge that we are all made of the same substance as are the stars, and the sea:

> … we are all sprung from heavenly seed. All alike have the same father, from whom all-nourishing mother earth receives the showering drops of moisture. Thus fertilized, she gives birth to smiling crops and lusty trees, to mankind and all the breeds of beasts. She it is that yields the food on which they all feed their bodies, lead their joyous lives and renew their race …[15]

There is a sense of luminous calm and serenity about the poem, which comes from understanding that there are no capricious gods demanding of us difficult things, and punishing us. There is a vibrant and airy joyfulness, beginning with the marvellous opening verses dedicated to Venus, a radiant symbol of the creative force of nature:

> Before you the winds flee, and at your coming the clouds forsake the sky. For you the ocean levels laugh, the sky is calmed and glows with diffused radiance.[16]

There is a deep acceptance of the life of which we are an integral part:

> Do you not see that nature is clamouring for two things only, a body free from pain, a mind released from worry and fear for the enjoyment of pleasurable sensations?[17]

And there is a serene acceptance of the inevitability of death, which cancels every evil and about which there is nothing to fear. For Lucretius, religion is ignorance; reason is the torch that brings light.

Lucretius's text, forgotten for centuries, was rediscovered in January 1417 by the humanist Poggio Bracciolini, in the library of a German monastery. Poggio had been the secretary of many popes, and was a passionate hunter of ancient books, in the wake of the celebrated rediscoveries made by Francesco Petrarch. His rediscovery of a text by Quintilian modified the course of the study of law throughout the faculties of Europe; his discovery of the treatise on architecture by Vitruvius transformed the way in which fine buildings were designed and constructed. But his triumph was rediscovering Lucretius. The actual codex found by Poggio has been lost, but the copy made by his friend Niccolò Niccoli (now known as the Codex Laurenziano 35.30) is still preserved in its entirety in Florence's Biblioteca Laurenziana.

The ground was already surely prepared for something new when Poggio gave Lucretius's book back to humanity. Already, from Dante's generation, it had been possible to hear markedly new accents:

> Your eyes went shooting through my heart
> to wake my dormant thought.
> Look now, I'm desperate and distraught
> with love that tears my life apart.[18]

But the rediscovery of *De rerum natura* had a profound effect upon the Italian and European Renaissance,[19] and its echo resounds, directly or indirectly, in the pages of authors ranging from Galileo[20] to Kepler,[21] and